Cuba. ‘We cannot have the present government there go on.’[35] On 28 January 1961, Dulles briefed Kennedy and his advisers, including McGeorge Bundy, Robert McNamara, Dean Rusk, General Lyman Lemnitzer (Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff), and Vice President Lyndon Johnson. Over the next three months, Kennedy reviewed the plans and made changes with significant repercussions for the operation. Yet it is clear he did not understand the implications of various decisions (and his advisers failed to make him understand).

One misunderstanding involved the Joint Chiefs of Staff, who were asked to review the CIA plan. They were unhappy that a CIA para-military operation usurped their authority and displaced their prerogatives in military affairs. They preferred an overt US landing to remove Castro and install a government with whom the United States could do business. However, their doubts about the operation were not properly communicated to the President, who believed their conclusion expressed endorsement rather than acquiescence. McGeorge Bundy misrepresented the Joint Chiefs’ view of the CIA plan as ‘enthusiastic’.[36] Their assessment stated that the operation had ‘a fair chance of ultimate success’.[37] The use of the word ‘fair’ was designed to express limited confidence. The joint chief’s evaluation had been drafted by a team led by Major General David Gray, in whose opinion the operation had only a thirty per cent chance of success.[38]

The Joint Chiefs’ analysis, moreover, was based on CIA assurances that an amphibious landing would trigger a popular revolt. Lemnitzer and his colleagues also believed that if the landing failed, the United States would openly intervene. That critical assumption was shared by the architects of the plan at the CIA. As McGeorge Bundy later observed, ‘It never occurred to Bissell that if push came to shove, Kennedy wouldn’t put in his stack.’[39] Allen Dulles recollected: ‘We felt that when the chips were down, when the crisis arose in reality, any action required for success would be authorized rather than permit the enterprise to fail.’[40] The DCI’s experience of Eisenhower’s reactions in the Guatemala operation presumably informed his judgement on this critical matter.